In 1984, the insurgents were provided with more sophisticated weapons to shoot down Russian jets and attack helicopters. There was also some sort of unity among various insurgent factions, which was not visible earlier. Although Soviets and Afghan intelligence tried to encourage defections, it was a complete failure.

Ashfaq told me that India was becoming a bit uneasy about the ongoing conflict because the ISI led by Lt General Akhtar Abdur Rahman was preparing a force of terrorists that they intended to use in Kashmir once the Afghan insurgency ended. The new prime minister, Rajiv Gandhi, wanted to strengthen ties with Western countries, especially the Americans, and he knew such a move would sour India's relationship with Moscow.

The R&AW by this time had developed a formidable capability for collecting and evaluating intelligence streaming in from abroad. Reddy said Rajiv Gandhi was suspicious of KGB activities in India and though he held a meeting with Mikhail Gorbachev in Moscow in 1985, he quietly directed the domestic spy agency, the Intelligence Bureau (IB), to take out a Russian trojan horse that may have infiltrated the Indian government machinery.

'Rajiv wanted to balance the ties between Moscow and Washington and he was right in a sense. You cannot put all your eggs in one basket and since he was focused on empowering India's technical sector, it was impossible to avoid the USA. The strain between New Delhi and Moscow now became too obvious,' Reddy recalled. He added that the R&AW's sole focus during Rajiv's term in office was terror outfits and training camps. There were estimated to be around one hundred and twenty Markazud Dawah (learning centres) based